School Readiness: Do Parenting Classes Make a Difference?

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RONALD E. McNAIR POST-BACCALAUREATE ACHIEVEMENT PROGRAM

ABSTRACT

Getting children ages 0 to 5 to be ready for kindergarten is one of the state's top priorities, giving the widening achievement gap between racial/ethnic minority and Caucasian students. This study evaluated a parenting program that tries to get Lao children ready for kindergarten by working with Lao parents and grandparents on their parenting skills. Fifty-one parents and grandparents participated in 3 parenting classes for 8 weeks. The results showed that participants who took the classes have significantly changed their beliefs about pre-kindergarten children and become more involved in the monitoring of their children's activities. The retrospective indicators revealed that, on average, 89% of the participants reported that they changed their parenting knowledge, confidence, communication, and techniques "a little bit" or "much more" compared to before they started the program. Implications of the findings and lessons learned from administering the program were also discussed.

PURPOSE OF RESEARCH

The purpose of this study was to examine what effects Lao parenting program have on Lao parents' and grandparents' parenting beliefs and practices. It was hypothesized that Lao parents and grandparents who took the parenting class would significantly increase their parenting beliefs and practices compared to before they took the class.

LITERATURE REVIEW

- It is acknowledged that to close the achievement gap, parents need to be provided with the necessary skills and resources, since research shows that parental education and involvement have a tremendous impact on children's development.
- Sheila Cordry and colleagues state that parents are children's first teachers and therefore have a lot of influence since they spend about 43,800 hours with their children before kindergarten (Cordry, Notar, & Friery, 2004).
- Most teachers agree that they cannot do it alone and want parents to be involved in their children's education (Wilson, Cordry, Notar, & Friery, 2004).
- Yet, studies showed that Southeast Asian parents are less involved in their children's education due to low literacy, language barriers, cultural expectation differences, and socioeconomic challenges (Portes & Rumbaut, 2001; Tang, 2000; Xiong, Yang, & Lee, 2007; Xiong, Detzner, & Cleveland, 2004).

RESULTS

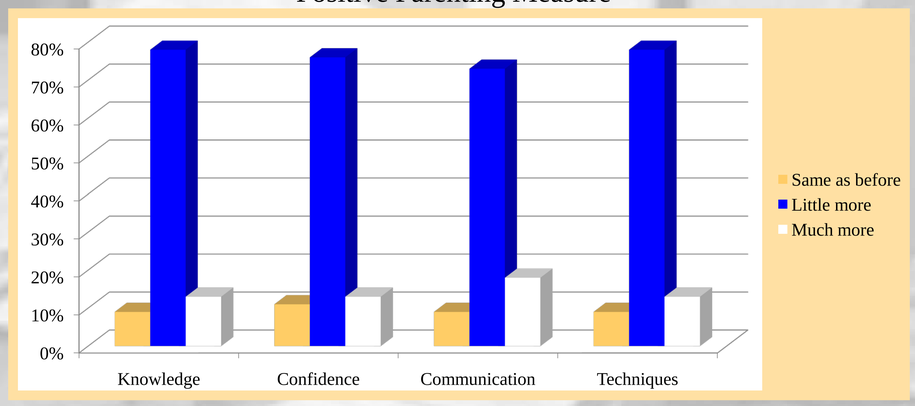
Changes in Parental Beliefs about Children Zero to Five

Item	Mean (SD)	t	Sign. (2-tailed)
Pair 1: Children 0 to 5 are too young to learn.	.41 (1.15)	1.938	.06
Pair 2: Children 0 to 5 cannot stay still to learn.	.52 (1.21)	2.295	.03
Pair 3: Children 0 to 5 only want to play, not learn.	.50 (.88)	3.000	.00
Pair 4: It is difficult to teach children 0 to 5.	.79 (1.26)	3.378	.00
Pair 5: It is more important to make sure children 0 to 5 are safe than teaching them something.	.66 (1.56)	2.255	.03

Changes in Parental Monitoring

Think back to before the Lao parenting class and describe how different you are doing things now compared to before the class	Worse than last year	Same as last year	A little better than last year	Much better than last year
I monitor my child's activities.	0%	2 (6.9%)	14 (48.3%)	13 (44.8%)
I make rules for my child and on what he/she can and cannot do.	0%	3 (10.3%)	17 (58.6%)	9 (31%)
I make sure my child has a set bedtime.	0%	2 (6.9%)	14 (48.3%)	13 (44.8%)

Positive Parenting Measure



Participants' Evaluation of the Classes

Item	Strongly Agree	Agree	Mixed/ Undecided	Disagree	Strongly Disagree
1. I find that the information used in this class was appropriate for the Lao people.	82.8%	13.8%	0%	0%	3.4%
2. I find the curriculum used in this class fits Lao parents and grandparents well.	62.1%	34.5%	0%	0%	3.4%
3. I find the parenting ideas/strategies in the Lao curriculum used in this class fit Lao parents well.	82.8%	13.8%	0%	0%	3.4%
4. I am satisfied with the way the teacher taught the class.	62.1%	34.5%	0%	0%	3.4%
5. I feel I can approach the teacher at any time.	72.4%	20.7%	0%	3.4%	3.4%
6. I have learned a great deal from taking this class.	62.1%	31.0%	3.4%	0%	3.4%
7. I would recommend this class to other Lao parents, grandparents, and caretakers.	79.3%	13.8%	3.4%	0%	3.4%

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METHOD

Participants

This study evaluated 51 participants who took the classes. Of the 51 parents who completed the classes, 51% were grandparents, 40% were biological parents, and 9% were uncles, aunts, or relatives. Sixty-five percent were female and 35% were male, ages ranged from18 to over 56, with a mode of 46-55. The majority of the participants were married (81%) and have no college education (91%). Ninety-six percent of the participants were born in Laos; however, 86% of them have lived in the United States for more than 10 years.

Recruitment

Participants were recruited using word of mouth via a snowballing sampling approach, beginning from the participants who were already enrolled in one or more programs at the organization, without any incentive first. However, after a few months of unsuccessful recruitment, a $10 incentive was added to attract more participants. This resulted in 65 interested parents and grandparents for the three separated classes. However, due to scheduling conflicts only 51 parents and grandparents completed the classes.

Measures

There were three different measures used in this project: Beliefs Scale (taken before and after the program), Parental Monitoring Scale and the Positive Parenting Measure (retrospective design).

LESSONS LEARNED

- We have learned that recruiting parents to our classes in our agency was very difficult since many Lao parents work outside the home and in nonstandard shifts.
- We have learned that many of the grandparents did not have access to transportation access to transportation.
- We learned that when recruiting parents without any compensation they were less likely to be interested in the program.
- We have learned that completing all the forms for each participant and his or her child was extremely difficult since most parents/grandparents do not read and are not familiar with forms and surveys.
- We have learned that there needs to be more translated materials for each module in order for the parent educator to facilitate the work.
- We have learned that it is time-consuming to put a quality but culturally relevant curriculum together.